

India POST: India's Parliamentary Office of Science and Technology

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Abstract

This paper argues that India should establish a dedicated parliamentary science office, modeled on the UK Parliament's Parliamentary Office of Science and Technology (POST), to strengthen legislative scrutiny in an era of rapid technological and scientific change. It examines the limits of India's current institutional arrangements, where executive bodies such as NITI Aayog provide valuable policy expertise but do not substitute for an independent, parliamentary-level scientific advisory function. Drawing on comparative institutional analysis and scholarship in Science and Technology Studies, the paper shows that a legislative science office would give Parliament a non-partisan, evidence-based capacity to assess complex issues in areas such as artificial intelligence, digital governance, climate adaptation, and public health. Such an office would enhance democratic accountability by helping legislators evaluate technical claims, challenge executive assumptions, and make more informed decisions. The paper concludes that an Indian POST should not be understood as a duplicate of executive advisory institutions, but as a necessary complement that strengthens Parliament's capacity to deliberate independently and govern scientifically.

Introduction

The quality of legislation depends not only on democratic procedure but also on the depth and rigor of parliamentary deliberation. As scientific and technological developments accelerate, legislatures face growing pressure to assess emerging risks, contested evidence, and complex policy pathways (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; OECD 2019). In domains such as artificial intelligence, digital governance, climate adaptation, and public health, policy decisions increasingly hinge on technical judgments that are not easily accessible to legislators without specialized support. To keep pace with rapid innovation and make technical knowledge directly available to India’s Parliament, the legislature could benefit from establishing its own parliamentary science office, modeled on the UK Parliament’s POST (UK Parliament, n.d.).

India’s Parliament does maintain general research and support structures, including the Lok Sabha Secretariat and related parliamentary services. However, these bodies primarily provide broad administrative and documentary assistance rather than a dedicated, anticipatory, and independent scientific advisory function. This distinction matters. A legislature that relies only on executive or administrative sources may struggle to evaluate technical claims independently, especially when those claims are shaped by the policy priorities of the government of the day. As Sheila Jasanoff has shown, legislatures often face a structural weakness when they lack internal capacity to test technical evidence and challenge assumptions without depending on executive expertise (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004). A permanent parliamentary science office would help ensure that parliamentary debate remains grounded in evidence, reduces the influence of unverified claims, and strengthens democratic accountability in public administration (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; Weingart 1999).

This issue is especially important in India because Parliament must scrutinize legislation in contexts where executive bodies, while technically competent, are not institutionally neutral in the same way as a legislative office. NITI Aayog plays an important role in strategic planning and policy coordination, but it is a government think tank positioned within the executive branch and accountable to the government rather than to Parliament itself. Its knowledge production is therefore shaped by executive priorities and political timing. A

parliamentary office, by contrast, would serve elected representatives across party lines, including opposition members and backbenchers, thereby strengthening the independence and breadth of legislative scrutiny. The need for such an institution is not merely administrative; it is institutional and democratic (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004).

Methodology

This study adopts a conceptual institutional analysis, drawing on comparative documentation from the UK Parliament’s POST and India’s NITI Aayog, alongside established scholarship in Science and Technology Studies (STS) (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; NITI Aayog, n.d.; UK Parliament, n.d.). The analysis evaluates the structural similarities and differences between executive advisory institutions and legislative scientific support bodies, with attention to issues such as independence, mandate, and parliamentary function. It also examines how a legislative science office could fit within India’s parliamentary framework, including possible institutional placements under the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha Secretariats or as a direct support mechanism for department-related standing committees, such as the Standing Committee on Science and Technology.

This paper does not generate primary field data. Instead, it offers a comparative and normative account of institutional design, grounded in the logic of legislative independence and evidence-based scrutiny. This approach is appropriate for assessing the viability of a parliamentary science office in India, particularly because the central question is not simply whether technical expertise exists in the state, but whether the institutional arrangements available to Parliament are capable of producing independent scientific advice for legislative decision-making (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; Weingart 1999). The method is therefore designed to clarify the comparative institutional gap between executive knowledge production and legislative evidence support.

Institutional Design Considerations

A parliamentary science office in India would need to be designed to serve a distinctly legislative function rather than simply replicate executive advisory structures. The key difference is not the existence of expertise, but the relationship between expertise and democratic accountability. Executive bodies such as NITI Aayog can provide high-quality policy analysis to the government, but that does not resolve Parliament’s need for independent, non-partisan technical assistance. A parliamentary office must therefore be answerable to legislators, not to the executive branch, and must be structured to support scrutiny, debate, and oversight across party lines (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004).

Several design features would be important. First, the office should operate with an explicit mandate to support parliamentary committees, members of Parliament, and legislative deliberation rather than to implement government policy. Second, it should maintain normative independence from the executive, including in staffing, publication, and advice-giving. Third, it should be capable of producing both short-form briefings and longer analytical assessments on emerging technologies, regulatory risks, and cross-sectoral policy challenges. Fourth, it should function as a trusted source of neutral evidence for opposition parties and backbenchers as well as ruling-party legislators. These features would distinguish an Indian POST from existing advisory or research bodies and make it more closely aligned with the institutional needs of a representative legislature (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; Weingart 1999).

Institutionally, several placements are possible. The office could be established under the Parliament Secretariat, with a direct reporting line to the Speaker or a joint parliamentary oversight mechanism. It could also be attached to the standing committees that deal with technology, science, environment, health, and digital regulation. A more integrated model would combine both: a central office providing technical expertise to Parliament as a whole, with committee-specific support for legislative scrutiny. Regardless of exact placement, the crucial principle is that the office must act as a legislative resource rather than an executive advisory unit (UK Parliament, n.d.).

Discussion and Conclusion

Scientific advice for legislatures is distinct from executive policy advice because its primary purpose is to support legislative deliberation, scrutiny, and public accountability rather than to directly implement government policy (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; Weingart 1999). In this sense, a parliamentary science office is not simply another expert unit within the state apparatus. It is a mechanism for strengthening Parliament’s ability to exercise independent judgment, challenge executive assumptions, and make technically informed decisions in the public interest. This distinction is especially significant in contemporary India, where legislative issues increasingly involve complex technical evidence, cross-sectoral impact, and long-term societal consequences (OECD 2019; IPCC 2023).

While NITI Aayog plays a vital role in executive strategic planning, its institutional position as a government think tank is fundamentally different from that of a parliamentary office serving elected representatives directly (NITI Aayog, n.d.). NITI Aayog can provide expertise to the government, but it does not resolve the structural problem that Parliament lacks an internal, independent scientific capacity. This distinction is crucial in areas such as artificial intelligence, climate adaptation, energy transition, and digital regulation, where legislative decisions must balance scientific uncertainty, public accountability, and political judgment (OECD 2019; IPCC 2023).

The case for an Indian POST is therefore not a claim that executive advisory institutions are unimportant. Rather, it is a claim that legislative scrutiny requires a different institutional form. One body advises the government, while another strengthens Parliament’s ability to scrutinize, question, and deliberate independently. That distinction is essential in an age of complex regulation and rapid technological change. An Indian parliamentary science office would help ensure that lawmaking remains not only democratic but also scientifically informed and institutionally resilient.

The establishment of an Indian POST should therefore be regarded as a necessary institutional complement to existing executive bodies, not as a redundant or duplicative measure. It would give Parliament a durable, non-partisan source of technical insight and would

strengthen the quality of legislative deliberation across political lines. Further research should assess the direct impact of the UK Parliament's POST on legislative efficiency and policy outcomes to provide stronger empirical grounding for reform. For India, creating a parliamentary science office remains a vital institutional step toward strengthening the scientific foundations of democratic lawmaking (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; UK Parliament, n.d.; Weingart 1999).

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